COLONIAL THEATRE

Colonial Theatre in Nigeria

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

What the colonial stage brought, what it suppressed, and how Nigerians took the imported forms and made a popular theatre out of them.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- mission schools
- concerts and cantatas
- the colonial city
- censorship
- appropriation

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The imported stage

Colonial theatre arrived with three institutions: the mission school, the church and the colonial club. The schools staged concerts, cantatas and Shakespeare; the churches staged nativity plays and Easter cantatas; the clubs staged drawing-room comedy for a European audience. None of it was meant to produce a Nigerian theatre.

What it produced was a generation of Nigerians who had learned the machinery of the stage - the proscenium, the script, the rehearsal, the ticket - and would turn it to their own purposes.

The concert

The school concert was the most widespread theatrical form in colonial Nigeria: songs, sketches, recitations and a short play, performed at Christmas, at speech day and at the visit of a dignitary. It taught performance to thousands of people who never entered a theatre building.

From the concert came the concert party: a professional entertainment with a band, a comic sketch, a female impersonator and a highlife finale. In Ghana it became a national form; in Nigeria it fed directly into the travelling theatre.

The colonial city and its audience

Lagos, Ibadan, Enugu and Port Harcourt acquired halls, cinemas and a paying audience of clerks, teachers, traders and colonial officials. Touring companies from abroad played Shakespeare and musical comedy; local companies played to the same audiences with a different repertoire.

The colonial authorities also censored. Plays about taxation, forced labour or the abuses of the courts were refused a licence, and the theatrical argument moved into music, satire and allegory - a technique that post-colonial playwrights inherited.

Appropriation as strategy

The most important fact about colonial theatre in Nigeria is that Nigerians took it. They staged Shakespeare in Yoruba, turned the cantata into a folk opera, put highlife into the concert party and used the proscenium for plays about their own towns. The colonial form was the vehicle, not the destination.

Read the colonial period, then, as a period of training and theft: the tools were imported, the use was local.

Sources: how we know

The colonial theatre is documented unevenly. The colonial administration kept files on licences, censorship and public order; the missions kept school and church records; the newspapers - the Lagos Weekly Record, the West African Pilot and their contemporaries - carried notices and reviews; and private collections hold programmes and photographs.

Read the administrative files against the newspapers. The file tells you what the state feared; the notice tells you what the audience was offered; the review tells you what a contemporary thought of it. Where the three disagree, you are close to the history.

Oral history matters here more than for any other period on this shelf. People who performed in school concerts

and church cantatas in the 1940s and 1950s are still alive, and their memories of the repertoire, the rehearsals and the audience are primary sources. Record them, with permission, and cite them properly.

Censorship as a theatrical fact

The colonial licence was not only a legal instrument; it shaped what playwrights wrote. A play that could not mention a tax riot could still put the argument in a song, a proverb or a masquerade, and audiences learned to read the code.

That habit of indirection did not disappear at independence. It is one reason Nigerian political drama so often works through allegory, festival form and satire rather than direct statement, and a student reading the post-colonial plays without the colonial censorship will miss half of what they are doing.

Exercises

1. Trace one form - the concert, the cantata, the school play - into its post-colonial descendant.
2. Read a colonial-era Nigerian newspaper advertisement for a play and describe the audience it assumes.
3. Stage a two-minute scene in the style of a 1930s school concert, then in the style of a travelling theatre.

Where to read more

Ebun Clark, Hubert Ogunde: The Making of Nigerian Theatre (1979)

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria (1981)

David Kerr, African Popular Theatre (1995)

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